

Snippets

Tata launching solar plans with new financial model

Tata Power Solar, an Indian solar manufacturer and developer, is all set to launch a nationwide initiative, which may open the access to solar finance for residential use. Tata has collaborated with one of the largest loan and finance companies, Bajaj Finance, to offer a monthly instalment payment option for solar power users, without interest. This national finance programme will be rolled out across 20 cities in the first phase and slowly expanded to other parts of the country.

India explores desert renewable energy strategy

The Indian government is exploring the possibility of the country's deserts providing the ideal location for a new wave of wind and solar energy projects. Reportedly it has started to work on assessing the viability of mega-scale renewable energy projects in the Thar Desert in Rajasthan, Rann of Kutch in Gujarat and Ladakh in J&K.

Philips to set up standalone LED company

Royal Philips will soon start the process of combining its Lumilets (LED components) and automotive lighting businesses into standalone company within the Philips Group. This company will explore strategic options to attract capital from third-party investors for this business. It intends to remain the shareholder and customer of the new company, and will continue the existing innovation collaboration.

India Electronics and Semiconductor Association (IESA), will set up the incubation centre. According to DeitY, "The total project cost approved for assistance is ₹ 211 million. STPI will set up an incubator facility of 930 square metres (10, 000 square feet) as part of this project. At least 50 start-ups will be supported over a period of 5 years."

Plans to boost technology innovation in rural India

STMicroelectronics, a global semiconductor company, has announced a strategic cooperation with India's National Innovation Foundation (NIF) under the aegis of the Department of Science and Technology, government of India, to support technological innovation in remote areas of India and create a marketplace for the result of that innovation.

The close relationship with ST will help NIF and other network members convert technological inventions conceived within the 'Honey Bee' network of like-minded individuals, innovators, farmers, scholars, academicians, policy makers, entrepreneurs and NGOs, into the mainstream business. Honey Bee collects ideas from all over India

through a drive called ShodhYatra (search trip) and brings rural innovation to light to help mankind, besides mobilising ideas of technology students from hundreds of colleges across India through techpedia.in

Through this unique relationship, NIF will emphasize complete product development, while ST will validate and develop electronic solutions for some of the innovative ideas and convert them into value-added technologies/products that can potentially make a difference to the masses. STMicroelectronics and the National Innovation Fund urge talent to come across geographical barriers and encourage formation of innovation clusters across the country.

Inverted duty, infra issues affecting IT hardware sector

Facing challenges like inverted duty structure and infrastructure bottlenecks, IT hardware industry has urged the new government to take corrective measures to bring back growth in the sector that has been witnessing flat growth in the last few years. The existing players are now hopeful of

positive changes coming in as the new government headed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi settles down to tackle issues affecting economic growth of the country. Issues like high inflation and soaring prices due to rupee fluctuation is also a constant worry for the industry.

Manufacturing of electronic hardware in the country has suffered on account of high cost of power and finance, high transactional costs and poor base of supply chain, thereby increasing dependence on imports. At present, around 65% of the current demand for electronic products is met by imports and the remaining, mainly low-end products, are manufactured locally. According to IESA-Frost & Sullivan's Indian ESDM Market report, the ESDM (electronic system design and manufacturing) industry was estimated to be US\$ 68.31 billion in 2012 and by 2015 it is expected to touch US\$ 94.2 billion.

Foreign direct investment policy clarified

As per extant FDI policy, FDI up to 100% under the automatic route is permitted in B2B e-commerce activities. The present policy does not permit retail trading, in any form, by means of e-commerce, for companies with FDI engaged in the activity of single/multi-brand retail trading. The following announcement in respect of FDI with reference to manufacturing sector was made by finance minister during his recent Budget speech:

"FDI in the manufacturing sector is today on the automatic route. The manufacturing units will be allowed to sell their products through retail including e-commerce platforms without any additional approval." Total FDI equity inflows during April 2000 to April 2014 in e-commerce into India is at US\$ 37.10 million, being 0.02% of the total FDI equity inflows of US\$ 219,286 million. No targets are fixed for FDI inflows, nor is an assessment of future inflows possible, as FDI is largely a matter of private business decisions.

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